Japan and the Age of Monsters:

Godzilla as a Construction of Crisis and Catastrophe

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Introduction

Stories of giant primordial beasts who threaten the safety and security of the human world once they are accidentally awakened are universally present in myths and folklore around the world, but few have been as globally beloved—and commercially successful—as Japan's Godzilla. Originally a story about an ancient sea monster whose slumber is disturbed by underwater nuclear testing, the myth of Godzilla has evolved to encompass diverse themes pertinent to the modern world: the specter of nuclear power, the destruction of marine life, the dangers of uninhibited progress, and the continuous threat of catastrophe; all of which stemmed from the vision of Shigeru Kayama, an anti-nuclear sci-fi author who created the story to embody the tragedy, horrors, and profound consequences of the use of nuclear weapons, and to warn future generations of the dangers of forgetting the lessons and traumas of the past.

Godzilla made his debut in director Ishirō Honda's 1954 film *Gojira*, a *kaiju* (trans. 'strange beast') blockbuster teeming with political and cultural commentary on the 1945 nuclear bombings in Hiroshima and Nagasaki, as well as the 1954 nuclear contamination of the tuna fishing boat *Daigo Fukuryū Maru* (Lucky Dragon No. 5). In early 1954, Tōhō Studios producer Tomoyuki Tanaka found himself intrigued by the possibility of tapping into nuclear anxieties and radioactivity concerns in Japan after learning about the commercial success of the 1952 remake of *King Kong*, as well as *The Beast from 20,000 Fathoms* (1953), an American science fiction film about a prehistoric monster who, after being released from its frozen hibernation by atomic testing, goes on a destructive rampage in New York City and showers the people with its radioactive blood. Emboldened by this potential, and having just had a promising Japanese-Indonesian film project canceled by Indonesian authorities due to anti-Japanese sentiment, Tanaka quickly approached science fiction and naturalist writer Shigeru Kayama and asked him to develop a treatment for the

film. Kayama, an anti-nuclear activist, injected his story with references to the real-life consequences of nuclear testing, wanting to critique the ongoing use of nuclear power and the scientific testing that endangered Japan's waters. Takeo Murata and Ishirō Honda then adapted this story into a screenplay and toned down Kayama's political messages, such as renaming the fishing boat in the opening shot from *Lucky Dragon No. 5* to simply *No. 5* and removing a key scene that referred to the 1952 hydrogen bomb tests at Enewetak Atoll and the 1954 Castle Bravo detonation at Bikini Atoll, which irradiated the atmosphere and waters shared with Japan (Angles 2023, 196). While Kayama was clear in his indictment of American nuclear weapons, Honda thought the references were "too overtly political" and sought to use Godzilla "not as an indictment of America but a symbol of a global threat" (Angles 2023, 199). He wanted to create the effect of "an invisible fear" that could tug the audience's memories and heartstrings using Godzilla as a proxy for the war, unlike Kayama who was more direct with his political messages and less concerned about the politics around its marketability.

The Beast from 20,000 Fathoms / Gojira / King Kong

Note the similar visual placement of the titular giant monster overlooking a major metropolis (New York City and Tokyo)

Honda's intuitions, along with the critical contributions from Kayama and other talents who worked on the film, produced a smash hit, setting a record not just for Tōhō but also for the science fiction film genre in Japan. Filmed in the style of a noir documentary rather than a gaudy sci-fi monster film, *Gojira* appealed to both monster enthusiasts and the generation of war victims whose lives were upended by the violent destruction of not just Hiroshima and Nagasaki, but also of all the cities that were relentlessly bombed by air raids between 1942 and 1945; even those who lived or evacuated to relatively untouched rural areas had lived in fear of the skies as these raids threatened to vaporize the infrastructural pillars of Japan. Furthermore, the film spotlights the effects of nuclear radiation on the human body by designing Godzilla's scales to resemble the keloid scars grafted on survivors of the atomic bombings. For historical context, all photographs and documentation of the injuries suffered by survivors were suppressed by the American occupation until its departure in 1952 (Dower, 2008), and the Japanese government only began providing the *hibakusha*—these atomic bomb survivors—a modest allowance in 1954 (Brodie, 2015). For many in the audience, this was likely their first time seeing the horrific effects of nuclear weapons on the *hibakusha* up close. *Gojira*, with its groundbreaking special effects and moving orchestral music, "[said] publicly what might otherwise appear unsayable, combating the coerced silence that is a favored weapon of those who have power" (Hamid, 2015); it became one of the first works of creative media in Japan to challenge the dominant narrative of History set into place by the American occupying authorities, who enacted these censorship laws to avoid international scrutiny over the ethics of detonating a nuclear bomb over a living population. Though the film lacked the critical punch that Kayama had crafted in his treatment, the visual depiction of a

radioactive monster burning through Tokyo was compelling enough to draw in an audience that, for the first time, had the opportunity to sit and reflect upon the horrors that they were still healing from.

The immediate success of *Gojira* launched one of the longest-running and most prolific media franchises of all time, spanning seven decades of films, TV series, animations, video games, novels, toys, comics, apparel, and more. The franchise is broken up into four major eras, each with its own idiosyncratic themes, visual styles, and overarching narratives that evolved alongside the cultural and political landscape in Japan.

1. **Showa Era (1954-1975):** The original Godzilla run comprised 15 films that saw Godzilla's transformation from a deadly nuclear force to a benevolent, sometimes even humanlike protector of humanity, who battles with other *kaiju* like King Ghidorah, Hedorah, and his own robotic clone Mechagodzilla to save Japan. Though this era explored many other thoughtful themes like pollution, childhood innocence, and futuristic technology, the films gradually became more oriented towards family-friendly fun characterized by epic monster battles and alien invasions.
2. **Heisei Era (1984–1995):** The reboot brought the Godzilla story back to its foundational roots in the interdependent relationship between science, nature, and human technology. Nuclear fears are foregrounded again in the context of the Cold War, with geopolitical tensions between America, the Soviet Union, and Japan featuring heavily in the first film of this era; the Three Mile Disaster in 1979 also served as a reminder of the continued threat of a nuclear meltdown (Skipper, 2022). Much of this era is colored with social commentary on the Cold War, particularly with themes of grief, loss, global tensions, and the threat of Earth's destruction.

3. **Millennium Era (1999–2004):** Unlike the previous two eras, Tōhō decided to reboot Godzilla as an anthology series rather than sharing continuity between the films. One significant entry in this era is *Godzilla, Mothra and King Ghidorah: Giant Monsters All-Out Attack* (2001): here, Godzilla is an embodiment of all those who were killed by the Imperial Japanese Army during World War II, representing their anger at the Japanese government's denial of their war crimes and society's cavalier attitude towards the millions who perished during the war. Rather than nuclear fears, the film is imbued with a spiritual/mystical angle that forces modern-day audiences to confront the dangers of forgetting the past, particularly in reference to Japan's continued denial of its own wartime atrocities (Skipper, 2022). Not only did this film stay true to Godzilla's anti-war themes, but it also, for the first time, challenged the Japanese audiences to position themselves within Japan's harmful legacy and confront the uncomfortable past, subverting Godzilla's familiarity as a cultural and sympathetic icon.
4. **Reiwa Era (2016–present):** After a decade, the franchise was reset again for the modern era. *Shin Godzilla* (2016) once again tapped into nuclear anxieties in Japan – not of the atomic bombings, however, but rather the more recent Fukushima Daiichi disaster that occurred in 2011. The film satirizes the Japanese government's failure to contain the disaster and coordinate a timely response. In the wake of Godzilla's arrival, bureaucrats waffle around in meeting rooms and high-rise offices while citizens are killed and Godzilla grows stronger. Scientists are discredited and their research is censored to keep up political appearances. The United Nations threatens to detonate a thermonuclear bomb to kill Godzilla should the Self-Defense Forces fail to subdue it, while the U.S. military intervenes with increasingly destructive air strikes. *Shin Godzilla* serves as a sobering reminder that

after six decades, the world still hasn't learned from its mistakes, leading to avoidable consequences and deadly, persistent catastrophes. The Reiwa era also marks Tōhō's partnership with Legendary Pictures for the debut of the MonsterVerse multimedia franchise, which transports Godzilla and his *kaiju* peers to the United States and the fictional Skull Island.

Over his seven-decade run, Godzilla has been reinterpreted and adapted by storytellers in Japan and beyond, constantly reimagined as a terrifying yet inevitable natural force, an evil nuclear villain, a benevolent protector of humanity, an animal lashing out at forces beyond its control, a victim of human arrogance, or a father defending his child from harm. A viewer who watches *Gojira* and *Godzilla, Mothra and King Ghidorah: Giant Monsters All-Out Attack* back-to-back might find themselves confused about the conflicting narratives of Japan as a wartime victim versus as a colonial aggressor. Such incongruence is possible because the Godzilla character itself carries no meaning, is simply a man in a rubber suit kicking a bunch of miniature sets around. It is the *storyteller* who imbues the story of Godzilla with purpose and meaning, the storyteller who wields Godzilla to "[create] an audience that could imagine specific references—whether to a family, a political event, or a mountain—as part of a growing spatiotemporal world to which the listener"—or viewer, in this case—"also belonged" (Wedeen, 2008). Whose vision, then, encapsulates the conflict between Godzilla and the modern world most effectively, and why is this critique so powerful? At the center of Godzilla's commercial and cultural success, what message pulses and reverberates so enduringly that storytellers across time and space—whether it be filmmakers, comic book artists, novelists, game designers, or radio producers—have felt no choice but to voice their stories through Godzilla?

I aim to ground these interventions in *Godzilla* (1955), the first of two novellas titled *Godzilla and Godzilla Raids Again*, written by Shigeru Kayama based on his original treatment for *Gojira* and newly translated into English by Jeffrey Angles in 2023. While much of Godzilla's fame is often credited to director Ishirō Honda, special effects director Eiji Tsuburaya, and musical composer Akira Ifukube, not much attention has been paid to Shigeru Kayama's original vision for the story, which is perhaps why it has taken nearly seven decades for an English translation to see the light of day. In this essay, I argue that this groundbreaking novella positions Godzilla not as a world-ending culmination of catastrophes, but rather as an ongoing, everyday sort of crisis that the Japanese people must continuously overcome in order to survive the disorienting and rapidly evolving world of the post-war era, wedged between a deeply painful past and a future fraught with infinite challenges and similarly infinite possibilities. Kayama articulates the pain of living in an uncertain world where the trauma of war and the threat of disaster have become embedded in the din of daily life, and through this pain, ultimately offers a vision of a future predicated upon cautious hope that is informed by the lessons learned from the past.

Dwindling Catches, Missing Boats, and the Crisis at Ōdo Island

Situated along the great Pacific Ocean, Japan has faced numerous calamities originating from the sea, including tsunamis, coastal earthquakes, fishing shortages, and eroding shorelines. It comes as no surprise that Godzilla, then, was written by Kayama as a sea creature whose kind "probably used to live hidden away in underwater grottoes, living out their lives, keeping to themselves, and managing somehow to survive until this day" (Kayama 1955, 48); an ancient animal peacefully embedded in Japan's shared ecosystem, until the H-bomb test destroyed his habitat and drove him up to the surface. The novella opens with a Japanese freighter encountering a mysterious fatal phenomenon at sea, and a second ship dispatched to rescue it encounters the same fatal end shortly after. Shinkichi, who works for Tokyo Bay Rescue and Salvage, learns that his brother Masaji is the only survivor of the rescue mission and returns to his native Ōdo Island to check on his mother and brother. Ōdo is virtually antithetical to Tokyo, a small island whose residents scrape together a living primarily by fishing. During the war, natives of Ōdo Island were "evacuated to the mountainous region of Shinshū in central Japan" (Kayama 1955, 9), indicating that this region had already once suffered from the Japanese Empire's involvement in the Pacific War. Despite this history, the islanders are presently more concerned about their dwindling catches and the strange disappearances than Japan's geopolitics; in fact, two Ōdo fishermen cautiously dismiss the possibility of a war breaking out in the following conversation:

> "If it had been an airplane, there should've been lots of American boats there to stop it."
> "I wonder if there's going to be another war."
> "But if there was a war, seems like the enemy would go after big American battleships, not Japanese boats."
> "Yeah, certainly not little fishing boats like ours…" (Kayama 1955, 25)

This seemingly innocuous exchange reveals what Kayama is building up as the characters' prevailing sense of 'post-war' Japan: a nation that, at this point, is not anticipating another earth-shattering catastrophe to happen, having just experienced one a decade prior. To the fishermen of

Ōdo, the possibility of another war brewing on the horizon has nothing to do with them and their "little fishing boats", especially now that the United States has established a military presence in Japan. Rather, the unrevealed threat of Godzilla lurking beneath the waters is likened to the threat of perpetual empty nets and missing boats, a crisis that resonates more immediately and tangibly in their daily lives. Upon learning of Masaji's fate, the villagers recall the folktale of Godzilla and quickly gather to "hold a kagura ritual to drive away misfortune" (Kayama 1955, 29), but are interrupted by the presence of Hagiwara, a reporter from New Japan News in Tokyo. He belittles Masaji's recollection of events and ridicules the villagers' rituals, even going so far as to exclaim, "Damn it! I can't make a story out [of] this." (Kayama 1955, 28), more concerned about generating headlines than the potential loss of Ōdo's livelihood. Hagiwara's presence in the third chapter juxtaposes the stark realities lived by Ōdo's struggling islanders with that of the 'modern' Tokyo urbanite: while the fishermen lament the loss of their boats and catches, Hagiwara arrives in a company helicopter and swaggers around dismissively, igniting tension and panic among the villagers and disturbing their ritual, before Godzilla, finally, makes landfall in Ōdo.

This slow crawl of an introduction creates a foreboding sense of crisis that is very much localized in the 'rural sacrifice zones' of Japan—vulnerable regions sacrificed in the pursuit of economic and political development (Matsumura, 2011). Ōdo is destroyed twice by Godzilla, a byproduct of the nuclear arms race during the Cold War era, and is barely mentioned again throughout the rest of the book, almost as if Tokyo was the main spectacle all along and Ōdo was merely setting the stage for this cautionary tale. As the sole survivor of Godzilla's ambush at sea, Masaji's survival brings Shinkichi and Ōdo a miraculous sense of hope and relief, but this too is quickly extinguished during Godzilla's land raid soon after, when Masaji and their mother are crushed in their home under Godzilla's clawed foot. Raising his "blood-covered face into the

howling wind", Shinkichi screams, "*Mother!!! Masaji!!!*" and "kept screaming as he struggled to crawl little by little toward the crushed ruins of his house" (Kayama 1955, 35), grieving the family of which *he* is the sole survivor now. Here, Shinkichi learns a valuable lesson: that the *threat* of catastrophe is never over, and as long as humans continue to pervert the balance of nature, Godzilla will come again and again and rain terror upon Japan, starting with the little islands and the fishing boats that stand no chance against the *kaiju*'s might.

Reading this, I couldn't help but think of the Minamata disease outbreak that occurred in the 1950s and 60s. A small industrial city in the Kumamoto Prefecture of Japan, Minamata's residents suddenly began to suffer from a mysterious neurological disorder of unknown origin, which poisoned not just the people but the animals they lived with and depended on as well, leading to extreme convulsions, loss of bodily function, reproductive failures, and death (Kugler, 2023). The disease was eventually traced back to the presence of the highly toxic methylmercury in the industrial waste discharged by the Chisso chemical factory into Minamata Bay, which fed the fishing villages in Minamata. Again, a chain reaction set off by the people on top chasing profit and power, pulsing its devastating consequences through the sea. "They say that when [Godzilla's] eaten all the fish in the sea, he comes onto land and eats people," an elderly Ōdo fisherman reflects somberly (Kayama 1955, 30). Indeed, the Minamata tragedy reinforces not just this interdependent nature between Japan and the sea, but also the magnitude with which the sea *hits back*: first it poisons the fisheries ("it eats all the fish in the sea"), which destroys the local and regional food supplies ("then comes onto land"), leading to a healthcare and economic collapse in Minamata and a wider sense of paranoia around seafood ("and eats people"). This is a lesson that Japan continues to grapple with even today, as evidenced by the recent news of Fukushima Daiichi nuclear plant's decades-long plan to release its buildup of treated radioactive wastewater into the Pacific starting

from August 2023, a decision that has been met with backlash from local fishing groups and governments of neighboring countries (Yamaguchi, 2023).

Certainly, Japan is not the only country that has had to deal with the effects of toxic marine waste and environmental pollution, but the scale of mass nuclear testing that has occurred in or near the area and the nation's nature as an archipelago have inevitably engendered a sense of precarity in this interdependent relationship, a feeling that cultural anthropologist Anne Allison encapsulates as 'ordinary refugeeism': a buildup of mundane catastrophes that slowly deteriorates one's sense of home and belonging (Allison, 2013). This buildup is understandably dramatized in Kayama's project, but it aligns with Allison's picture of a 'precarious Japan' just the same: Godzilla did not spawn out of nowhere, after all, but was rather a product of negligent nuclear testing, geopolitical power struggles, and a callous disregard for the health of the environment—dysfunctions that continue to persist even to this day, effectively positioning the *kaiju* as part of the 'crises of the everyday' (Aalgaard, 2019). While Ōdo is only present in the first four chapters of the novella, the crisis there effectively sends a crucial signal to the rest of Japan at large: if the sea isn't safe, then the cities aren't safe, so then it can be reasoned that nowhere is safe, leaving the nation vulnerable to the looming threat of Godzilla.

Air Raid Sirens, Evacuating Trains, and Déjà Vu in Tokyo

After the events at Ōdo Island, Kayama permanently shifts the setting to Tokyo and Tokyo Bay, where the other characters reside: Professor Yamane, a paleontologist who spearheads the research on Godzilla; Dr. Serizawa, a brilliant but cold scientist who had been injured in the war; and Emiko, Yamane's daughter who acts as a lynchpin between the two men and Shinkichi. Also populating the scenes are bureaucrats and government representatives, who fight among themselves over whether or not the information about Godzilla being a dangerous "unintended off-spring of experiments with the H-bomb" should be made public, lest it causes "all sorts of trouble—political problems, economic problems, [and] diplomatic problems…" (Kayama 1955, 50). This prescient snapshot of a congested and failing bureaucracy would later be a central narrative in Tōhō's 2016 reboot *Shin Godzilla*, which also drew from the Japanese government's disastrous response to the 2011 Fukushima nuclear meltdown and the proximate Tōhoku earthquake and tsunami. What interests me, though, is that this is how Kayama introduces the readers to Tokyo: as a discordant cacophony of opinions and reactions, each competing to further their own interests in the name of science (Yamane), diplomacy (Representative Ōyama), revenge (Shinkichi), or cautious progress (Serizawa). By allowing the characters to fracture from each other in the face of a common enemy, Kayama's project thus forms a cultural production that is located "in many sorts of reciprocal contexts" as it wrestles with the polyvocality of various agents and subjects of power, and finds "diverse ways of rendering negotiated realities as multisubjective, power-laden, and incongruent" (Clifford and Marcus, 1986). Kayama intentionally roots this big blockbuster script in the tender reflection of a past shared by many but perhaps experienced differently, and in the process created a 'national imagining' (Ben Anderson, 1991), a *creative* imagining, with which the Japanese public could use to articulate the social, political, and

economic anxieties that they faced in their everyday lives, anxieties that turned out to not have been reset to zero or wiped clean by the nuclear bombs. Consider the following scene, in which three nameless characters casually discuss the news of Godzilla's arrival:

> A crowded train on the Keihin Line had just left Ueno Station in Tokyo and was heading north toward Ōmiya. In it, two male students who appeared to be in middle school were chatting with a cute female student who had dimples on her cheeks and a gentle curl in her bangs.
> She said, "How awful! First we had radioactive tuna and radioactive rain, now Godzilla…What on earth do you think will happen if he makes his way up to Tokyo Bay?"
> "He'd gobble you up in a single bite. First thing!"
> The girl shot back, "You're such a jerk. I finally managed to recover from the atomic blast in Nagasaki, so I'm going to take care of myself…"
> "I imagine we'll have to start thinking about evacuating. We'll have to think about where to go."
> "Evacuating? You mean going to the countryside?"
> "What choice is there? All of us young people are going to waste our youth out in the boonies…"
> The girl started laughing. "Listen to you whining about your youth. I was evacuated last time around."
> "No way. I didn't mean to be rude. Do you remember?"
> "Boy, you are rude!" She gave the student to her right a gentle slug on the shoulder.
> "Gosh, evacuation, eh? What an irritating world we live in." (Kayama 1955, 51-52)

In *The Kaiju Film: A Critical Study of Cinema's Biggest Monsters*, author Jason Barr describes artist Takashi Murakami's 'superflat' art, which intermingles cute and bright objects with the bizarre and horrific, as "reflective of Japanese society after the atomic bombings: in one part infantilized and returned to a state of perpetual childhood, and in the other part horribly deformed" (Barr 2016, 37). The above scene echoes this artistic sentiment by contrasting the innocence of the mischievous young schoolboys and the girl with the "dimples and gentle curl in her bangs" with the horrifying threat of Godzilla, which they discuss with a sort of mundane casualness as if it were only a slight disturbance in their everyday routines. The girl complains about the "radioactive tuna and radioactive rain", alluding to the real radioactive tuna scare that followed the *Lucky Dragon No. 5* incident, and is seemingly unfazed by the threat of this 'third nuclear bomb', having just recovered from the one that hit Nagasaki years prior. The

schoolchildren consider the whole affair to be an irritating disruption that would only lead to a 'wasted youth' spent in the countryside, a tragedy assumed to have been left behind in the past and one that these young students cannot, or perhaps do not want to, seriously comprehend. Through this brief scene with its nameless characters, we are struck again with the blanket of mundanity, the lack of *emergency*, that has swept over this 'post-war Japan', the same one that caused the Ōdo fishermen to scratch their heads about their "little fishing boats" and dismiss the threat of another great catastrophe breaking out. I want to stress that it is important not to generalize the real historical context here—*emergency* was certainly something that loomed over Japan's head at the time, what with the Cold War underway in neighboring regions and the global stockpile of nuclear weapons continuing to grow. Rather, I believe that Kayama intentionally deploys these dual tropes of ignorance and innocence to bring attention to the granular, everyday anxieties that have taken up these characters' lives; to focus, however briefly, on the small, quiet crises that tend to be overlooked in the chaos of global politics and large-scale catastrophes. Amidst the loud chatter between the politicians and scientists and military men, Kayama makes clear the importance of recognizing how easily the dreams, ambitions, and compulsions of the everyday people could be caught and forgotten in the crossfire of the Empire's legacy, even as Japan rebuilt and reached new heights in the second half of the 20th century. Just as how the schoolchildren in this scene realize that the threat of a 'wasted youth' is not an artifact of the war, but rather a continued crisis that could crop up at any point in time, Kayama makes the intervention that disaster and catastrophe, as world-ending as they may feel, never truly reset the world and fade in the distance; they instead become embedded in the landscape of the everyday. Time after time again, nuclear bombs rise up from the sea, children lose their youth to the 'precarious Japan' (Allison, 2013), and bureaucracy proves itself to be slow-moving and ineffective. A depressing warning to make, for sure, but a

necessary one in the context of this time as well: amidst the post-war economic boom and trade surpluses that generated large profits for Japan, Kayama reminds readers both then and now that the cost and consequences of war always have some way of sneaking back into the present, and thus it is critical that we confront and address the lingering pain of historical traumas in order to move forward and shape a better future. Having healed from the blast in Nagasaki, the girl in the scene above believes that she can "take care of herself" this time around and imparts a warning for the younger schoolchildren to take the evacuation seriously. Though their fates are never revealed, the scene ultimately presents a gentle, precarious hope for the students' survival: that if the girl could survive, learn from, and move on from a 'world-ending' catastrophe such as the one in Nagasaki, the younger schoolchildren might stand a chance at surviving Godzilla too—but only if they accept the gravity of the evacuation and take seriously the lessons of the past.

Throughout the story, Kayama continues to ground the chaos of Godzilla's landfall in tropes and elements that highlight the recency of war in order to shed light on the deep traumas of the past, which in turn allows him to offer a vision of future for the characters and his Japanese audiences at large. He breaks the fourth wall and addresses the readers at certain points in the novella—readers who, at this point, would have been able to freshly recall the blare of the air raid sirens and the panic that ensued: "Some of you readers probably know how weird and unsettling it can be when terrified people are running around in a panic as sirens wail overhead, high and low, their trailing notes reverberating across the landscape… The continuous, drawn-out sounds of the sirens coming from every direction sounded like sobbing" (Kayama 1955, 69). In the aftermath of Godzilla's first attack on Tokyo, there is a scene where Emiko cares for an orphaned baby while the Geiger counter testing the little girl "[lets] off an unsettling clicking sound" (Kayama 1955, 94); nothing else is said of this, but this short, quiet scene would have undoubtedly struck a chord

with audiences who were watching a new generation grow up in the shadow of the nuclear bombs and the Japan Empire's legacy of war. Kayama is also careful not to solely memorialize "Japan's role as victim of wartime violence" (Bourdaghs 2012, 62) through Professor Yamane, who champions the study of Godzilla in hopes of protecting the world from a similar catastrophe in the future: "Fortunately, this amazing chance…has been given to Japan. We Japanese have caused a great deal of trouble to people throughout the world. Carrying out this research is our one and only chance to make reparations for all that" (Kayama 1955, 66). Dr. Serizawa, the scientist who secretly comes up with a weapon far more dangerous than a hydrogen bomb to defeat Godzilla, initially refuses to share it with anyone but Emiko, fearing that his Oxygen Destroyer would fall into the hands of global superpowers who would abuse it and profit from mass suffering, the same way World War II and the Pacific War had been mongered by those at the seats of power in a fight for power and control. Even Godzilla himself is said to only be an animal whose habitat was destroyed and whose body was mutated by the hydrogen bomb tests that were conducted by humans. In weaving these threads of consequence, complicity, and tragedy together, Kayama prompts his audience to confront the multifaceted nature of the post-war experience, from the individual traumas to the collective responsibility for preventing future calamities. The vision he offers is not just a reflection on the past, but a contemplation of the choices that shape the future, emphasizing the importance of learning from past mistakes to forge a path toward a more responsible and conscientious existence.

This message is made most clear in Dr. Serizawa's arc, who reluctantly agrees to deploy the Oxygen Destroyer under the condition that he will destroy his research and kill himself to prevent anyone from recreating another world war, securing what he believes to be a peaceful future for his friends, colleagues, and the people of Japan. After defeating Godzilla, Shinkichi,

Professor Yamane, Emiko, and the crew sail back to Tokyo in relief and sadness, wondering, "What if…What if the hydrogen bomb tests were to continue?…Who knows? Maybe more of his kind might appear somewhere on earth" (Kayama 1955, 111). Here, Godzilla transforms from a single blamable beast to an abstract possibility of future catastrophes, perpetuated by the same mistakes that people refuse to learn from. But the ending also presents a message of hope: Dr. Serizawa's actions prove that it *is* possible to broker a peaceful future through responsible and ethical means, and that crises, however large or small, can be overcome by learning from history and each other, forming a 'communal belonging' (Wedeen, 2008) that is predicated upon empathy, shared responsibility, and a collective commitment to ethical decision-making. This is, of course, not an easy lesson to internalize in real life; much like how the Fukushima disaster occurred anyway despite decades of anti-nuclear activism in Japan, the characters' hard-won peace is immediately paratextually shattered by the big, bold words on the next page: **GODZILLA RAIDS AGAIN**. Crises never go away, and the world never resets. Life keeps marching on. But the characters—and us, the readers—have learned a valuable lesson: that the pursuit of a better future is worth trying and hoping for anyway, and worth the collective effort to build despite the persistent challenges and uncertainties that may arise.

Conclusion

For a character so deeply rooted in Japan's post-war history, Godzilla and the *kaiju* trope have been redeployed endlessly to articulate crises and anxieties elsewhere in time and place. The 2014 American reboot *Godzilla*, for example, depicts the nuclear-charged Godzilla as an ally of the U.S. military, turning Kayama's critique of nuclear power on its head and deploying 'Orientalist filters' (Said, 1978) to spotlight the military in a triumphant show of power. The 2006 South Korean film *The Host* uses a *kaiju* to critique U.S.–South Korea relations after an American civilian employee of the U.S. Forces Korea was caught dumping formaldehyde down a drain, contaminating the Han River. The 2008 film *Cloverfield* uses live footage recordings to capture the destruction of New York from a street-level view, evoking memories of the 9/11 attacks. Upon re-watching these films to bolster my understanding of this project, I found it fascinating that these reinterpretations of Kayama's story were able to resonate so deeply, in their own incongruous ways, with people from all walks of life. What is it about this story, of a sea monster that rises from the depths of the ocean to punish humans for their transgressions against nature, that transcends cultural and temporal boundaries, resonating so profoundly with audiences across diverse contexts? Why keep reminding people that the threat of disaster never goes away, that life must be lived in anticipation of crisis and catastrophe? What makes Kayama's critical intervention so effective that it has to be told over and over?

The answer to these questions, I believe, lies in Kayama's message of hope: that the story of Godzilla can always be retold because humans always have the capacity to hope for a safer, more peaceful, and more prosperous future, whether in the wake of major catastrophes like climate disasters or something as simple as the mundane challenges of daily life. Godzilla may represent destruction, but out of that destruction comes change, rebirth, regrowth—a 'purifying fire' (Walker,

2015) that allows for endless chances to make better decisions this time around, one step at a time. It is crucial, though, that these decisions are made with the knowledge of history and past mistakes in mind in order to propel forward towards a kinder and more forgiving future.

In the novella, Dr. Serizawa blesses Shinkichi and Emiko with a happy life, right before he cuts his breathing tubes and drowns the secrets of the Oxygen Destroyer along with him. In *Godzilla Minus One* (2023), which I watched in a nearly empty theater at the end of December, *Shinsei Maru* captain Akitsu does the same to their young crewman Mizushima, whom the grizzled crew force to stay behind to avoid the battle. Seventy years apart, and the hope for a better future in the face of tragedy continues to endure. Much like the characters in the Godzilla stories, we continue to defeat our monsters, pick up the pieces, and march towards the possibilities of a brand new day.

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